Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, Varahamihira and others. He relates stories from the two epics and other mythologies. He presents the Hindu science of grammar and metrical composition. He describes their social customs and hierarchies. He also compares Hindu thought to the Greek thought of Socrates, Pythagoras, Plato, Aristotle, Galen and others, and at times with Sufi teaching.

'The Hindus use the numeral signs in arithmetic in the same way as we do,' he writes (a couple hundred years earlier, zero and the decimal system had been adopted by the Muslim world, and were then transmitted to Europe as Arabic numerals[20]). 'I have composed a treatise showing how far, possibly, the Hindus are ahead of us in this subject.' He also translated two books into Arabic 'one about the *origines* and a description of all created beings, called *Samkhya*, and another about the emancipation of the soul from the fetters of the body, called *Patanjali'*.

After this deep immersion in Brahminical texts and society, Alberuni begins *India* with several general remarks about the Hindus and their society. He explains that just as the 'confession, "There is no god but God, Muḥammad is his prophet", is the shibboleth of Islam, the Trinity that of Christianity, and the institute of the Sabbath that of Judaism, so metempsychosis [reincarnation] is the shibboleth of the Hindu religion. Therefore, he who does not believe in it does not belong to them, and is not reckoned as one of them'.

Muslim and Hindu religions are poles apart, he writes. But while Hindus argue internally, they never physically fight over theological disputes. Instead, 'their fanaticism is directed against . . . all foreigners. They call them *mleccha*, i.e., impure, and forbid having any connection with them [via a] relationship, or by sitting, eating, and drinking with them, because thereby, they think, they would be polluted'. This, he thinks, 'constitutes the widest gulf between us and them'.

Alberuni gives the Hindus a wide berth as he considers that 'the repugnance of the Hindus against foreigners increased' after 'the Muslims began to make inroads into their country'. But this isn't the only reason for the barriers he senses between the Muslims and the Hindus. The barriers are also caused by other 'peculiarities of their national character, deeply rooted